The Great Basin

The Great Basin region is located in between the Sierra Nevada and the Rocky Mountains with the Colorado Plateau in the south. The region consists of a mixture of lakes, salt flats and deserts. A number of tribes who spoke a dialect of the Uto-Aztecan or the Shoshonean languages lived in this region. These tribes included the Ute, Paiute and the Bannock. They lived by hunting animals such as lizards and by eating plants they could find. Their homes were known as wikiups and were created by using poles made from willow trees. The homes were not permanent and could be moved in case of an emergency. The tribes had their own form of government which involved invocations and input from the leaders.

When the Europeans moved into the area, the Native Americans in the Great Basin region purchased horses. They created hunting parties that would go on to raid neighboring tribes. During the middle of the 19th century, the settlers discovered the area was rich in gold and silver. The natives did not want to leave and so most of them were killed.